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*The Left Hand of
Darkness*

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Truth is a matter of the imagination.
The soundest fact may fail or prevail in
the style of its telling: like that singular
organic jewel of our seas, which grows
brighter as one woman wears it and, worn
by another, dulls and goes to dust. Facts
are no more solid, coherent, round and
real than pearls are. But both are sensitive.

— Gently Ai

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On the fickle nature of "Truth".

King in his own eyes is Kharide

— -Prime Minister Estraven

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To a king, or rather a madman, his country is not its people,
its culture, or its struggles. It is nothing but himself: his
pride and his power. The nation is the king's ego: every
wound to it is a wound to him, every praise of it is praise
of him. Every judgment of the nation is a judgment of the
king.

When I say patriotism. I mean fear.
The fear of the other. And its expressions are political, not poetical: hate, rivalry, aggression. It grows in us that fear. It grows in us year by year.

— Prime minister Estraven

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progress is less important than presence.

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To exhibit the perfect uselessness of the knowing the answer to the wrong question

— Faxe

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On the planet Winter, the Handdarata is one of the two major religions, the other one being the Yomeshta. The cornerstone belief of the Handdarata is that one should strive towards ignorance, while the Yomeshta hold that all of time was seen at once by Meshe, and so all is already known, all is light. Despite the pursuit of ignorance, the Handdarata follow the mystical ritual of foretelling. The ritual has primarily the asker and the foretellers: the asker gets to ask one question, usually at a high material cost and often an even higher personal cost. It seems funny that the religion of ignorance has the ability to foretell the future so exactly. The foretellings seldom bring the solace the asker sought; rather, their lives are further worsened by knowing than by unknowing. It goes to show the value of ignorance to human existence, and the futility of chasing certainty, for a life fully known is death.

Ignorance is a ground of thought.
Unproof is the ground of action.

— Faxe

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Faxe: What is known? What is
sure. predictable, inevitable-the
one certain thing you know con-
cerning your future and mine ?

Genly Ai: That we shall die.

Faxe: ... The only thing that makes life
possible is permanent, intolerable uncer-
tainty: not knowing what comes next.

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